The Lower Paleolithic tools are also found in the North Arcot and Dharmapuri districts. The people belonging to this period used **basalt rocks** for manufacturing artefacts. However, the southern part of Tamil Nadu and Sri Lanka do not have evidence of Lower Paleolithic Culture.

**Basalt rocks are igneous rocks:** Igneous rocks are those formed from the molten lava from the earth.

The Lower Paleolithic Culture is datable to about 2 - 1.5 million years at Athirampakkam. Th is cultural phase continued in other parts of India up to 60,000 years ago.

## Middle Paleolithic Culture in Tamil Nadu

In the course of time, the **Middle Paleolithic Culture** emerged during 3,85,000 - 1,72,000 years ago. The tool types of this period underwent a change and smaller artefacts were used. Cores, flakes, scrapers, knives, borers, Levalloisian flakes, hand axes and cleavers are the artefact types of this period. Compared to the previous phase, these tool types became smaller in size.

Evidence for the Middle Paleolithic Culture can be observed in some parts of Tamil Nadu. In the southern part of Tamil Nadu, at T. Pudupatti and Sivarakkottai, artefacts of the Middle Paleolithic tools have been collected. Also near Thanjavur and Ariyalur, similar artefacts have been found.

## Mesolithic Culture in Tamil Nadu

In many parts of the world, and in some parts of India, the Upper Paleolithic Culture succeeded the Middle Paleolithic Culture. There is no evidence for the Upper Paleolithic Culture in Tamil Nadu. But the people who used **microliths** or small-stone artefacts lived in many parts of TamilNadu. Since this cultural period occurs between Paleolithic and Neolithic Culture, it is known as Mesolithic Culture or Middle Stone Age.



Microlithic flakes from Tamil Nadu

Evidence for the existence of Mesolithic hunter-gatherers is found at Chennai, North Arcot, Dharmapuri, Salem, Coimbatore, Ariyalur, Tiruchirappalli, Pudukkottai, Madurai, Sivagangai, Tirunelveli and Kanyakumari. The teri sites near Thoothukudi have evidence of microlithic artefacts. These sites have red sand dunes called **teris.**

The people of this period used small artefacts made of **chert** and **quartz**. The tool types are **scrapers**, **lunates** and **triangles**. These people hunted wild animals and gathered fruits, nuts and roots for their **subsistence**.

**Scrapers** are tools used for scraping the surfaces. Scrapers are similar to the tools used in the kitchen for removing skin of vegetables.

**Triangles** are tools in the shape of triangles.

**Lunates** are tools in the shape of a crescent.

## Neolithic Culture in Tamil Nadu

The culture that domesticated animals and cultivated crops is called Neolithic. It is known as the New Stone Age. The Neolithic people used polished stone axes called celts. Cattle rearing was their main occupation. They lived in small villages with houses made of thatched roof and walls plastered with



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